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Sandy Springs officer resigns amid Flock misuse investigation

Report alleges subject tapped data for personal gain

By CARL APPEN

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SANDY SPRINGS, Ga. — A Sandy Springs police officer has resigned after allegedly using the city's Flock camera network to help develop a surveillance product for a company where he works, according to interviews and documents obtained by Appen Media.

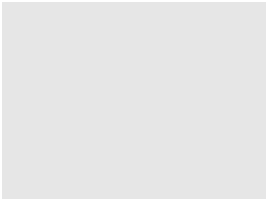
Public records show Francis Michael Esposito had been with the Sandy Springs Police Department since 2016. According to an internal affairs report and other materials obtained by Appen Media, he resigned in August amid a department investigation into his alleged use of city-leased software to help improve commercial data platform Signal 8.

The Sandy Springs Police Department uses products from Flock Safety, an automated license plate reader and security software company based in Atlanta. The firm's technology identifies and logs vehicles moving through town to assist police with criminal investigations.

Flock users can perform searches of identifying information – such as license plate numbers or descriptions – to help locate vehicles they suspect are connected to criminal activity. When departments make these queries, they can search certain databases of other agencies as well, tapping into a nationwide network of sources.

The platform also allows agencies to set up lists of vehicles to monitor, getting alerts if they appear in the network.

Flock says its system “is trusted by more than 5,000 communities across the country...” That figure includes all 10 of the cities and counties Appen Media covers in north Metro Atlanta.



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By CARL APPEN

Esposito joined the Sandy Springs Police Department in 2016 and was promoted to sergeant in 2021, according to public records obtained by Appen Media.

While employed as a Sandy Springs officer, Esposito began working for Canton-based Signal 8, a public safety software startup founded by former Sandy Springs Police Detective Brandon Puhlman, according to their LinkedIn profiles and other public materials.

Signal 8 connects “multiple systems in one interface to reduce time spent on administrative tasks” and help officers deploy quickly, according to its website.

Puhlman, who served with Sandy Springs Police from 2017 to 2021, did not respond to interview requests for this story. Esposito also did not respond.

Earlier this year, Esposito used his Sandy Springs Police credentials to conduct searches in the Flock network for the purpose of informing Signal 8 algorithms, according to a police internal affairs report obtained by Appen Media.

The report alleges Esposito searched Flock for license plate numbers belonging to himself and other employees of Signal 8 along with their families.

“Additionally, there were other entries identified relative to the same dates and reasons, but the names and vehicles could not be definitively identified,” as tied to Signal 8, it noted.

The report also alleges Esposito made searches for the personal license plate number of a fellow Sandy Springs officer.

Esposito's Flock queries were not made for law enforcement purposes, but instead "for the benefit of a private company for which he was employed," the investigation alleges. According to the internal affairs report, data gleaned from the searches was used to inform and improve the Signal 8 platform.

Sandy Springs Police officials also sent a letter to Flock Safety, which Appen Media obtained, alerting them to the allegations. In it they write that Esposito, "was utilizing his Sandy Springs Police Department Flock login to obtain Flock Camera data for commercial purposes to validate beta data for a product for a company identified as Signal 8."

Esposito was under investigation for the alleged actions when he resigned in August.

However, Sandy Springs officials say they consider his exit a termination. The reason, they told Appen Media, is because Esposito allegedly refused to answer questions during the probe.

"Frank Esposito was recently terminated after he failed to cooperate during an internal affairs investigation into possible misconduct," Sgt. Leon Millholland told the newspaper.

In September, Sandy Springs sent Esposito a letter, obtained by Appen Media through a public records request, informing him the investigation had, "concluded with sustained findings of violations of department policies: Abuse of Position and Authority; Common Sense and Judgement; Conduct Unbecoming." The notice also stated that Esposito's status, "is officially classified as Terminated, effective August 20, 2025."

Appen Media also learned Esposito was not an active-duty officer during the time he conducted the alleged Flock searches, according to state, city and other records obtained by the newspaper.

The internal affairs report alleges Esposito made the license plate inquiries from January to April.

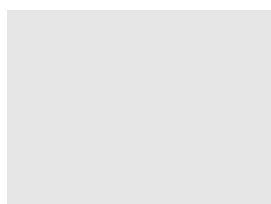
According to his personnel file and state records, Esposito resigned from his full-time post with Sandy Springs Police and joined the department's volunteer Reserve Unit in January.

“Reserve SSPD officers are unpaid sworn officers that volunteer 10 hours a month with the department,” Millholland said. “All Reserve SSPD officers have the same access to department resources and must adhere to the same policies and standards as full and part-time sworn officers.”

Appen Media asked Flock for its reaction to the allegations.

“Upon learning of the situation last month, Flock promptly addressed it directly with Signal 8,” Flock Safety Communications Officer Josh Thomas said.

Managing Editor Pat Fox, Staff Reporter Annabelle Reiter contributed reporting.



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